

Balcony & Container Gardening 101

1. Core Premise

Growing fresh greens, herbs, and compact vegetables requires minimal square footage when light, soil structure, and drainage are properly calibrated. Container gardening enables precise nutrient control and eliminates common soil-borne weed problems found in open-ground plots.

2. Action Steps

1. Assess Sun Exposure Accurately

Track the exact hours of direct sunlight your balcony or windowsill receives across an entire day. Sun-loving plants (basil, cherry tomatoes, chillies) require 6 or more hours of direct exposure; leafy greens (mint, coriander, spinach) thrive with 3 to 4 hours of partial or indirect sunlight.

2. Build an Aerated Potting Mix

Avoid heavy garden soil that compacts in pots and suffocates roots. Combine 40% cocopeat or compost (for moisture and nutrition), 40% standard topsoil, and 20% perlite or coarse river sand to promote aeration and root respiration.

3. Calibrate Watering by Soil Touch

Never water strictly on a calendar schedule. Insert your finger 2 to 3 cm into the potting medium; add water only when the surface feels dry, and ensure excess water drains freely through the pot's drainage holes without standing in bottom saucers.

3. Quick Reference & Best Practices

• Container Material Guide:

Use porous terracotta pots for drought-tolerant herbs to prevent waterlogging; use glazed ceramic or food-grade plastic containers for moisture-retaining greens.

• Feeding Strategy:

Apply a diluted liquid organic fertilizer (e.g., compost tea or seaweed extract) once every two weeks during active vegetative growth.